

Few and far between: A global perspective

VERY FEW COUNTRIES HAVE WOMEN LEADING THE FINANCE MINISTRY OR CENTRAL BANKS

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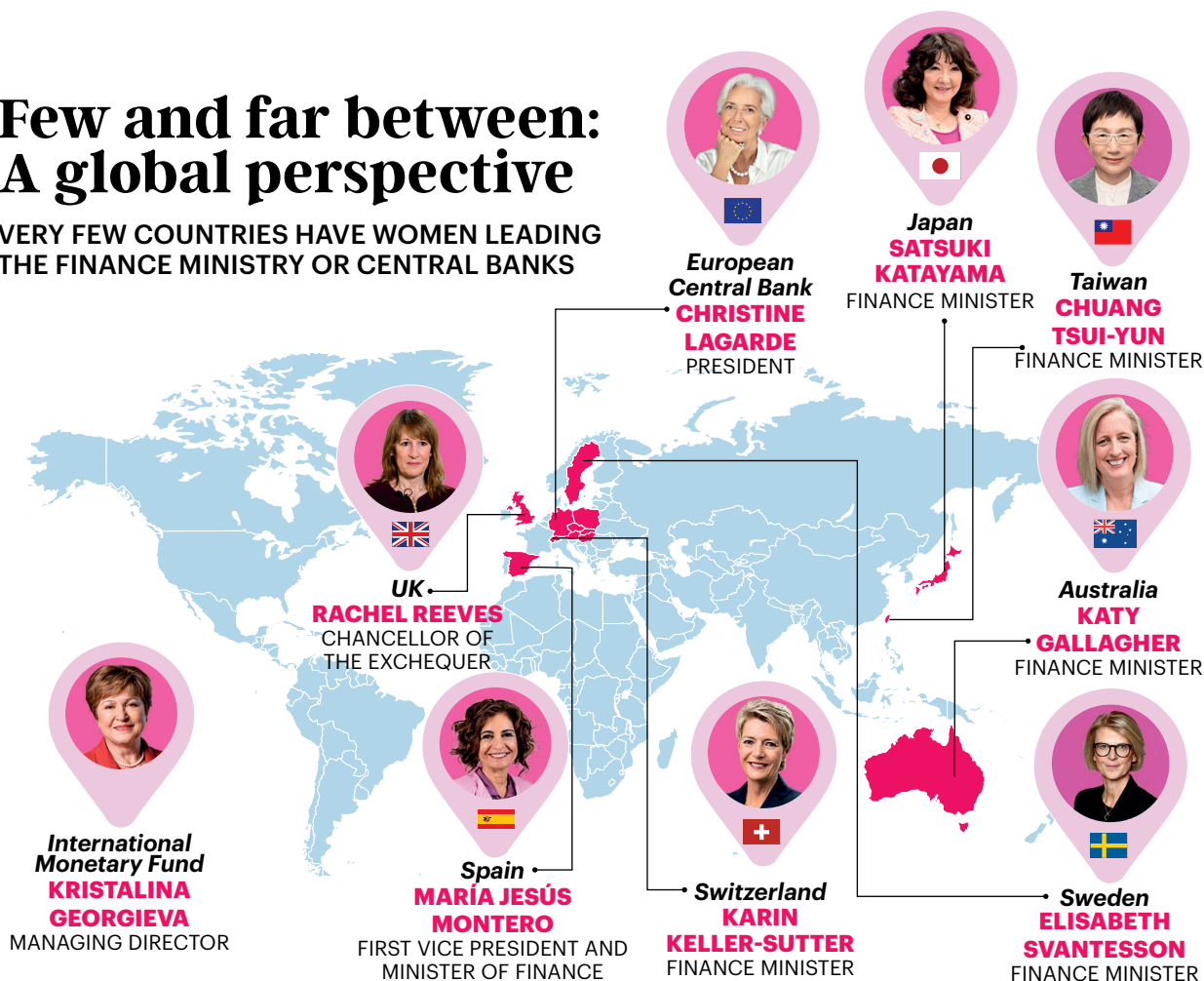


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has presented a record eight consecutive Budgets.

As if taking a lead, in a first, the Centre has appointed Anuradha Thakur, a 1994-batch IAS officer of the Himachal Pradesh cadre, as Secretary of the Department of Economic Affairs (DEA) in the Finance Ministry. Thakur, previously Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, was appointed Officer on Special Duty in the DEA in April and succeeded Ajay Seth when he retired on June 30.

The role of the DEA Secretary is very crucial. The person is responsible for managing the economy and formulating policies that will impact areas as varied as growth and inflation, capital markets, infrastructure financing and sustainable finance. The Secretary is also in charge of managing relations with international financial agencies, coordinating and preparing the Union Budget, and liaising with regulators like the Securities and Exchange Board of India and the RBI.

For instance, the economic liberalisation in 1991, led by Finance Minister Manmohan Singh, was overseen by

the then DEA Secretary Montek Singh Ahluwalia. During the demonetisation of 2016, DEA Secretary Shaktikanta Das oversaw the replacement of currency notes. Das went on to become the RBI Governor and is now Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister.

Other senior women officials in the ministry are Anu P. Mathai, Additional Secretary, DEA, and Parama Sen, Additional Secretary (Personnel), Expenditure.

Women officers at Secretary-level posts in the finance ministry have been few and far between. Sushma Nath was appointed Secretary in the Department of Expenditure way back in 2008 and went on to become the country's first woman Finance Secretary. Later, in 2015, Anjali Chib Duggal was appointed Secretary of the Department of Financial Services. Ila Patnaik, who is Chief Economist at the Aditya Birla Group, served as the Principal Economic Adviser in the finance ministry in 2014-15.

Dakshita Das, former Managing Director and CEO of the National Housing Bank, who worked in the fi-